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# Licenses, But Our Transportation Remains So Car-Centric

A third of Americans don’t drive. So why is our transportation so car-centric?

BY SARAH WESSELER

January 29, 2025

*This article was originally published by [Yale Climate Connections](#).*

According to the U.S. Department of Transportation, approximately [one-third of the nation’s residents](#) don’t have driver’s licenses. In her 2024 book “[When Driving is Not an Option: Steering Away from Car Dependency](#),” disability advocate Anna Zivarts

Disability Rights Washington, to raise awareness about the needs of local non-drivers. This grew into a larger project considering how these issues play out across the nation.

Yale Climate Connections spoke with Zivarts about her research.

*Interview was condensed and edited.*

**Yale Climate Connections:** Your book argues that there are far more people who don't drive in the U.S. than commonly assumed and that our transportation infrastructure doesn't serve their needs. Can you give me an overview of who these non-drivers are?

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Then there are folks who can't afford to drive. Some people I've talked to would drive if they had a vehicle that accommodated their wheelchair, but that's not something they can afford. And all sorts of folks can't afford vehicles for other reasons: Vehicle ownership is expensive; car insurance is expensive. And because of the racialized nature of poverty in our country, Black households are much less likely to have access to vehicles than White households.

And that doesn't get into who within a household has access to that vehicle. There are often a lot of dynamics within a household around gender or other issues that we aren't able to explore when we're just looking at [household members] as a single unit.

There are also people who don't have a driver's license for a lot of reasons.

Documentation, in some cases: While there are many states that allow undocumented folks to get driver's licenses, not all undocumented folks want to enter their information

that – but in many states, we see it happening for seat belt use or a broken taillight. There are all sorts of fines and fees that can accumulate and result in license suspensions. And that happens to poor folks, right?

Then there are people who are too young to drive. In some places, 10 to 15% of the population

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**YCC:** ... norms ... an international perspective. Can you say more about this?

**Zivarts:** In many other countries, children are given a lot more freedom to get around on their own because infrastructure is set up in a way that allows that. In some cultures within the U.S., though, expectations around parenting assume a lot of time and privilege to parent in really intense ways. When we create systems that assume that every child has a caregiver that can drive them everywhere they need to go, that creates a lot of exclusion, because there are families that don’t have that access, right? There are adult non-drivers with children they’re responsible for.

There’s been some interesting research by Dr. Kelcie Ralph at Rutgers around children who grow up without a driving caregiver. As adults, they have lower earnings and lower education attainment levels, even if you control for race and income, because so many opportunities are tied to access to driving.

percent can't be real. In my suburban or rural community, everyone drives." Or "It's not 30% if you don't count kids." To which I usually try to ask, "Well, at what age and with what abilities should someone get to be counted?" Is it 16? 18? 12? Starting first grade? Because all of us, even from the time of birth, need to go places. And not all of us can travel independently, even as adults. So why draw a line at all?

I've actually started beginning all my presentations by asking people to think about who they know in their own social circles who can't drive. It personalizes the issue and preempts some of this backlash I've received in the past – because generally, people do know people in their lives who can't drive.

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**YCC:**

system assume everyone drives? What is the logical outcome of that assumption?

**Zivarts:** Well, we leave people out, right? I think there's an assumption that, "Fine, there are people who don't drive, but they can get rides" – because most of our communities are so car-dependent that, for most non-drivers, that's how we get around. We end up relying on either our social networks or social services for rides.

But that always comes with strings attached: Someone has to sort of validate your choice every time you want to go somewhere. And even if you have a loving, caring partner who has all the time in the world to drive you where you want to go, the way you interact with the world is going to be filtered through that, right?

But there are lots of situations where people don't have a loving, caring partner who's able to give them rides. Say people need to get out of their household for safety reasons, or for health care reasons, and that option isn't available.

**YCC:** So how do we get to a system that works better for non-drivers?

**Zivarts:** The first thing is visibility. We need to help non-drivers understand, “You are not alone.” There are a lot of us, and we need to be more visible.

It also needs to be possible to imagine communities without cars. We lived that way before cars were invented, and there are places where it’s doable today, which I wish more people could experience. I spent 15 years in New York City, and it was so normalized not to own a car – that was really nice for me. My disability was much less

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- [17 Young People on the Moment the Climate Crisis Became Real to Them](#)
- [7 Ways to Manage Climate Anxiety](#)
- [Why Activists Go on Hunger Strikes](#)
- [In California, Incarcerated Teens Help Fight Wildfires](#)

[Sarah Wessler](#) is a writer and editor with more than a decade of experience covering climate change and the built environment. Originally from Ohio, she now lives in Brooklyn. ...  
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 The Most Unique Perfume Trends for Fall 2026, According to Experts

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### BEAUTY

## The Most Unique Perfume Trends for Fall 2026, According to Experts

From milky bases to floral and fruit combinations.

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## CULTURE

### HBO's *Harry Potter* Series Casts Moaning Myrtle, Colin Creevey, Tom Riddle, and More

See all of the cast announcements so far and how they compare to the original movies [here](#).

BY SARA DELGADO

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### STYLE

## John Galliano's 2027 Met Costume Exhibition Has Been Canceled

The designer announced his decision to back out of the exhibition, which serves as the base for the Met Gala, a month after the theme was unveiled.

BY SARA DELGADO

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IDENTITY

## Why a Luxury Fashion Group Is Investing in Youth Sexual Violence Prevention

We talked to teens and members of Project DOT to learn more about Kering's investment in young people.

BY ALYSSA HARDY

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## MUSIC

### Ed Sheeran Underestimates Young Fans By Saying They Shouldn’t Experience Politics at His Concerts

To imply that the young people in his audience should not have to hear the phrase “Free Palestine” is to condescend to them.

BY P. CLAIRE DODSON

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## CAMPUS

### Meet Teen Vogue's 2027 Campus Correspondents

Nine rising seniors from the class of 2027 will be giving regular dispatches from across country for the next two semesters.

BY ALYSSA HARDY

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CULTU

## Presley Gerber, Model and Mental Health Advocate, Dies at 27

Gerber died on Sunday, September 20, while at a rehab facility.

BY SARA DELGADO

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IDENTITY

## How a 21-Year-Old PR Intern Making \$20/Hour Spends Her Money

Welcome to Teen Vogue's Intern Math, where we explore how much it costs to be an interns in 2026.

BY MI-ANNE CHAN

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CULTU

## Millie Bobby Brown Reportedly Adopts Second Child With Jake Bongiovi

Here's what we know so far.

BY SARA DELGADO

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### STYLE

## Coach Is Bringing the Tabby Tour to a Campus Near You

We caught up with Tinashe at their first stop on New York City's NYU campus.

BY ALYSSA HARDY

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## MUSIC

### We Asked Daisy Chain Fields Attendees What They Loved About the Women-Led Music Festival

At Olivia Rodrigo's Daisy Chain Festivals music fest last weekend, the vibes were fun, safe, and whimsical, according to fans.

BY P. CLAIRE DODSON

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TV

## Meet Summer H. Howell, the Scream Queen Embodying a New Kind of ‘Carrie’

The star of Mike Flanagan’s latest Stephen King adaptation reveals how Carrie is different than we’ve seen her before.

BY MAX GAO